

NEW ZEALAND RESOURCE CENTRE

General Practitioner Registration Guide

Medical Council of New Zealand

Your complete guide to vocational registration as a GP in New Zealand — explained in plain English, for internationally qualified general practitioners.



Welcome to your registration guide

For internationally qualified general practitioners, registration with the Medical Council of New Zealand (MCNZ) is the gateway to practising as a vocationally registered GP here. The path is well-trodden — and for specialists, it works a little differently from other professions.

The most important thing to understand at the outset is the order of events. For many regulated professions you register first and find a job afterwards. **For doctors it's the other way around:** your MCNZ application is built around a **confirmed GP role and an approved supervisor**, so securing the right position is the genuine first step — and it's exactly where Ethicare comes in.

This guide explains the whole journey from beginning to end: confirming which pathway fits you, securing a role, verifying your credentials through EPIC, and working through MCNZ's vocational registration to full specialist status. It focuses on the things that genuinely make a difference and the small mistakes that quietly add weeks.

How to use this guide

Read it once from start to finish to understand the shape of the journey, then keep it nearby and return to each section as you reach it. Think of it as a handbook rather than a leaflet.

An important note

This guide complements, not replaces, the official guidance published by the Medical Council of New Zealand. The Council sets the rules and makes all registration decisions; where there is ever any difference, the Council's own published requirements always take precedence. Ethicare supports and guides you — and, as your recruitment partner, helps secure the role and supervision your application depends on — but we do not make registration decisions on the Council's behalf.

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A quick word before you start

Two things shape everything that follows: confirming your vocational pathway (Section 03) and securing a GP role with an approved supervisor (Section 02). Get those two right and the rest of the process is methodical.

Understanding the Council & the scope

The Medical Council of New Zealand — Te Kaunihera Rata o Aotearoa — is the regulator responsible for the registration and oversight of doctors in New Zealand. Its statutory role is to protect public health and safety by ensuring practitioners are competent and fit to practise.

The vocational scope

As a GP you'll be seeking registration in the vocational scope of **general practice**. Vocational registration is **permanent, specialist registration** that allows you to work independently in New Zealand.

The role of RNZCGP

Vocational training in this scope is delivered through the **Royal New Zealand College of General Practitioners (RNZCGP)**, leading to its Fellowship (FRNZCGP). When you apply as an international medical graduate, MCNZ asks RNZCGP — as the relevant college — to assess your training and experience and advise on your comparability. **The Council makes the final decision; the college advises.**

Registration vs. the practising certificate

Two related but separate things. **Registration** confirms you've met the standard to practise in the scope. The **practising certificate** is what then permits you to actually work. You cannot practise in New Zealand until your registration is confirmed and your practising certificate has been issued — and you can only work within the endorsement and any conditions noted on it.

Start with the self-assessment

Before anything else, use MCNZ's free online **registration self-assessment tool** — it points you to the pathway you're likely eligible for. We can direct you to it.

Why this guide focuses on vocational registration

This guide is written specifically for internationally qualified specialists applying for **vocational registration**, and it focuses on the MCNZ vocational pathways — VOC2, VOC3 and VOC4. The Council operates other registration routes for different groups of doctors, but those fall outside the scope of this guide. If you're unsure which pathway applies to you, Ethicare can talk it through with you before you begin.

Why the job comes first

This is the single most important thing to understand, and it surprises many applicants. As a specialist, your registration is built around a confirmed role — so securing the right position is the genuine first step.

A job offer is a prerequisite

To apply for provisional vocational registration you must **have a job offer in New Zealand as a GP at specialist level**. It isn't something you arrange afterwards — it's a condition of applying.

Your application is built with your employer

Once you have a job offer, you complete your MCNZ application **together with your employer**. Your employer's role is formally part of the process — the position and your nominated **supervisor** must be submitted to, and approved by, the Council (via the Council's position-and-supervisor approval form).

The supervisor is tied to the role

You'll work under supervision when you first register. Your supervisor must be registered and practising in the vocational scope of general practice, nominated by the practice / employer, and approved by the Council, and approved by the Council. Because the supervisor is attached to the position, you need the role before this part can be completed.

Where Ethicare fits

This is exactly where a recruitment partner earns its place. We match you to a GP role, work with the employer on the position-and-supervisor approval, and coordinate the application alongside your EPIC verification — so the job, the supervisor and the paperwork move together rather than in sequence.

Which vocational pathway fits you

For internationally qualified specialists applying to practise in New Zealand, there are three vocational registration pathways. Identifying yours early shapes the timeline and the evidence you'll need. Most of Ethicare's candidates use VOC4 or VOC3.

VOC4 — the fast-track (approved qualification)

If you hold an **approved postgraduate medical qualification recognised by MCNZ** for your approved area of medicine, you can apply via the **VOC4 fast-track**. MCNZ maintains a published list of approved qualifications; GP qualifications on that list don't need a separate college equivalence assessment, which makes this the quickest and most certain route. Always check your specific qualification against the current approved list (we can point you to it on the Council's VOC4 page).

VOC3 — individual assessment (qualification not on the list)

If your postgraduate general-practice qualification **isn't on the approved list**, you apply via **VOC3**, where your combination of qualifications, training and experience is assessed against the standard of the FRNZCGP, with RNZCGP advising the Council. The outcome is one of two findings:

- **"Equivalent to"** an NZ-trained specialist → a **supervision** pathway (typically reaching full vocational registration in around 12 months, though timeframes vary with individual circumstances).
- **"As satisfactory as"** (not fully equivalent) → an **assessment** pathway, which can include a Vocational Practice Assessment (a workplace-based assessment), commonly reaching full vocational registration in around 18 months, depending on individual circumstances.

Already hold FRNZCGP? Ask about VOC2

If you already hold the Fellowship of RNZCGP (the Australasian fellowship), the more direct route is usually **VOC2**, which leads straight to permanent vocational registration. It's a smaller group among international applicants, but if it's you, talk to us and we'll make sure you're on the right pathway.

The experience requirements

Beyond your qualification, MCNZ looks closely at recent, relevant specialist experience. The VOC4 thresholds are specific — evidence them clearly and you remove a common cause of delay.

VOC4 experience benchmark

For the VOC4 pathway you need a minimum of **24 months' clinical experience** (working at 0.5 FTE or more) in the **past 5 years** practising in your area of medicine — **including 12 months within the last 18 months** immediately before applying, in a country MCNZ recognises as having a health system **comparable** to New Zealand.

Comparable health systems

MCNZ recognises a defined list of countries as having comparable health systems (the UK, Ireland and Australia among them). Your recent experience needs to sit within those systems to meet the benchmark — confirm the current list against the Council's comparable-health-system criteria.

VOC3 experience

On the VOC3 pathway your experience is weighed as part of the college's individual comparability assessment against the FRNZCGP standard, rather than against a single fixed threshold. Recent, continuous practice in the same area and at a similar level of responsibility to your proposed NZ role carries weight.

Top tip — evidence continuity and level

Make your CV unambiguous on dates, FTE, and the level of responsibility you held. Use MCNZ's CV template where one applies to your pathway, and ensure your experience maps cleanly onto the GP role you're taking up.

EPIC / MyIntealth verification

Every overseas doctor must have key credentials verified at source before MCNZ can process the application. This is the step to start **early** — it can be the slowest-moving part.

What EPIC is

Since 2017, MCNZ has required **primary-source verification** of your qualifications through the **EPIC** service (the Educational Commission for Foreign Medical Graduates' Electronic Portfolio of International Credentials), now accessed via the **MyIntealth** portal. It confirms your credentials directly with the issuing institutions, independent of the copies you provide.

What to verify

- Your **primary medical qualification**.
- Your **approved postgraduate / specialist qualification(s)** — note that most applicants with UK or Irish postgraduate qualifications upload **two documents** as specialist qualifications.

Timing matters

You must send your documents for primary-source verification through EPIC **before you submit your MCNZ application**. Verification takes time, and **the Council can't begin processing until it has evidence the process is underway** — so open your EPIC/MyIntealth case as soon as your pathway is clear.

In practice, EPIC verification is often the **longest single part** of the whole process. It depends on universities and awarding institutions responding to verification requests, and their turnaround times are outside your control. That's precisely why you should begin EPIC as soon as you've confirmed your pathway and accepted the appropriate role — starting it early keeps it off the critical path.

Top tip — run EPIC in parallel

Don't wait for everything else to be ready. Start EPIC verification the moment you've confirmed your pathway and role, and let it run in the background while you assemble references and supporting documents.

Your supporting documents

Alongside verification, MCNZ needs a set of supporting documents. Assembling them as a clean, complete pack is the single biggest factor within your control on timing.

Identity & qualifications

Certified identity documents (with evidence of any name change), and your medical and specialist qualifications — verified through EPIC as above.

CV

An up-to-date CV using MCNZ's template where one applies to your pathway, detailing your training, experience, dates, FTE and level of responsibility.

Position & supervisor approval

The application for approval of your **position and supervisor**, completed with your employer — the formal step that ties your role and nominated supervisor into the application.

Specialty-specific information

For general practice, MCNZ may request additional information that RNZCGP needs in order to advise on your application — your recruiter and the college will guide you on exactly what's required for your pathway.

Cultural safety & Māori health

Cultural safety is an important part of practising medicine in Aotearoa New Zealand, and general practice places particular weight on Māori health. Depending on your employer, scope and pathway, you may be required or encouraged to complete cultural-safety education during induction or supervision — for example courses such as the Foundation Course in Cultural Competency (Māori), or working with the Hui Process / Meihana Model. Developing an understanding of Te Tiriti o Waitangi and Māori models of health supports safe, culturally responsive practice, and it's something you can begin building an understanding of early.

Present it like a professional portfolio

Clean, high-resolution colour scans; consistent naming; certification done correctly the first time. A well-organised application is assessed faster than a disorganised one containing exactly the same facts.

References, English & good standing

Three requirements with precise rules. Get them moving early — like EPIC, the parts that depend on third parties are the ones most likely to hold you up.

References

You provide **three references** on MCNZ's reference form (the RP6). Referees should be senior medical practitioners who have worked with you, generally within the past three years. The Council **verifies all references** as part of assessing your application, so accuracy and contactability matter.

Certificate of Good Standing (COPS)

A Certificate of Professional Status / Good Standing must be sent **directly from your current medical regulator** (for example the GMC or AHPRA) to MCNZ. It must be **received within three months of your NZ start date**, so time it carefully — if you have any disclosures, more than one may be needed.

English language

You must satisfy MCNZ's English-language policy. If English isn't your first language, or your training wasn't taught entirely in English, you'll provide evidence (for example IELTS Academic). Confirm the current accepted tests and scores against the Council's English-language policy before booking.

Common mistake — leaving COPS too late

Because the COPS must arrive directly from your regulator and within three months of your start date, request it on a deliberate timeline — not too early (it can expire) and not too late (it can delay your start).

Before you apply

Before you start the application itself, it's worth confirming a handful of things are in place. Running through this short list first is the simplest way to keep your application moving once it begins.

- ✓ **Confirm your likely vocational pathway**
VOC4, VOC3 or VOC2 — use MCNZ's self-assessment tool and talk it through with us.
- ✓ **Secure the appropriate GP role**
At specialist level, with an approved supervisor — the step everything else is built around.
- ✓ **Begin EPIC / MyIntealth verification**
Start it as soon as your pathway is set — it's often the longest part of the process.
- ✓ **Prepare your CV**
Using MCNZ's template where one applies, with clear dates, FTE and level of responsibility.
- ✓ **Identify suitable referees**
Three senior medical colleagues, generally from the past three years, for your RP6 references.
- ✓ **Gather certified identity documents**
Plus certified evidence of any name change.
- ✓ **Understand your likely timeline**
So the COPS, references and EPIC all land in the right window relative to your start date.
- ✓ **Speak with Ethicare before submitting**
A quick review of your evidence and pathway choice catches issues while they're still easy to fix.

Applying & the registration meeting

With your pathway confirmed, your role secured and EPIC underway, the application itself is methodical. Here's the sequence and a realistic sense of timing.

1

Apply online via myMCNZ

Create your myMCNZ account and complete the application — working with your employer.

2

EPIC verification underway

Evidence of primary-source verification must be in train before processing begins.

3

References, COPS & documents

Three RP6 references verified, COPS direct from your regulator, CV, English evidence, position & supervisor approval.

4

Assessment & college advice

MCNZ assesses your application (RNZCGP advises on VOC3). Vocational applications are commonly assessed within around 20 working days once complete, although this can vary with individual circumstances.

5

Eligibility-for-registration letter

Confirms — for agencies like Immigration NZ — that you can be registered, and sets up your registration meeting.

6

The registration meeting

Held once you've arrived in NZ, within about two weeks of your start date — identity, formalities, practising certificate and supervision are confirmed.

After the meeting

Following the registration meeting, and once your practising-certificate payment is received, the Council grants you registration in the **provisional vocational scope** and issues your practising certificate — allow around three days for it to be issued. **You cannot practise until your registration is confirmed and your practising certificate is in hand**, and you can only work within its endorsement and conditions.

Always check the current fees

We've deliberately not printed fee amounts here. Fees are reviewed periodically and there are separate EPIC and Council charges. Always confirm the current figures on the Council's official fees schedule before you budget or pay — we're happy to point you to it.

Begin your application early

A realistic rule of thumb is to start your application roughly **three to six months before** your intended start date — EPIC verification, references and the COPS all take time to land.

Supervision & full vocational registration

Provisional vocational registration is the supported first stage. Here's what supervision involves and how you progress to full, independent specialist registration.

Working under supervision

While in the provisional vocational scope you work under an approved supervisor. This typically includes an **induction and supervision plan**, regular meetings with your supervisor, and **supervision reports to the Council every three months**.

Supervision is a normal part of many vocational registration pathways, not a reflection of your competence. Its purpose is to support your transition into New Zealand clinical practice, and it generally becomes less intensive as your familiarity with local systems develops.

How long supervision lasts

- **VOC4 / "equivalent"**: commonly around **6–12 months** of supervised specialist practice, depending on individual circumstances.
- **VOC3 "as satisfactory as"**: an assessment pathway (which may include a Vocational Practice Assessment), typically reaching full vocational registration within around **18 months**.

Variations

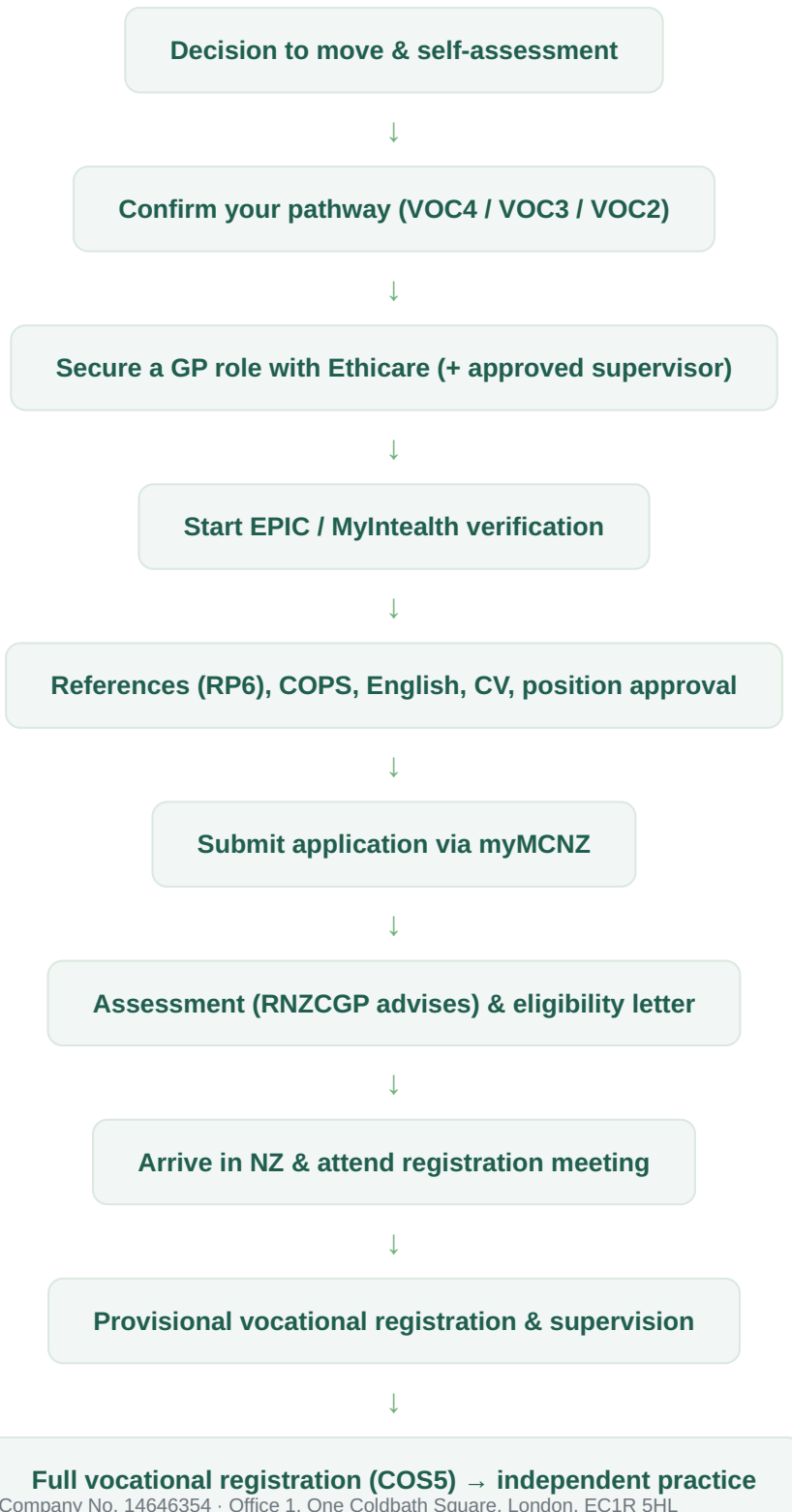
If your employment, position, supervision or location changes, you must apply for a **variation** to your scope **at least 20 days in advance** and wait for Council approval before working under the new arrangement.

Progressing to full vocational

Once you've completed the requirements set by the Council, you apply (via the COS5 form) to change your scope from **provisional vocational** to **full vocational** — permanent specialist registration that lets you practise independently.

Your registration journey

From first decision to independent practice — the whole journey on a single page. Note the order: for doctors, the role comes first.



Common mistakes to avoid

Almost every avoidable delay we see traces back to one of the issues below. Read this as a pre-flight checklist.

⚠ Treating registration as step one

For GPs the role and approved supervisor come first — the application is built around them.

⚠ Starting EPIC too late

MCNZ can't process until verification is underway. Open your MyIntealth case as soon as your pathway is set.

⚠ Wrong pathway assumption

Assuming VOC4 when your qualification isn't on the approved list (it's VOC3), or missing VOC2 if you hold FRNZCGP.

⚠ COPS timing

A Certificate of Good Standing not sent directly from your regulator, or not received within three months of your start date.

⚠ Thin experience evidence

A CV that doesn't clearly show the 24-month / recent-12-month benchmark, FTE, and level of responsibility.

⚠ Weak or unverifiable references

Fewer than three, or referees who aren't recent senior colleagues — MCNZ verifies them all.

✓ The fix for all of these

Confirm your pathway, secure the role and supervisor, start EPIC immediately, and let us coordinate the documents before submission.

Frequently asked questions

Do I really need a job before I can register?

Yes. A GP job offer at specialist level is a prerequisite for provisional vocational registration, and your nominated supervisor is tied to that position. Securing the role is the genuine first step — and where we help.

VOC4 or VOC3 — how do I know?

If your postgraduate general-practice qualification is on MCNZ's approved list, you're likely VOC4 (the fast-track). If it isn't, you're VOC3, assessed individually against the FRNZCGP standard with RNZCGP's advice. The self-assessment tool and a conversation with us will confirm it.

I hold FRNZCGP — which pathway?

Usually VOC2, which leads directly to permanent vocational registration and is more straightforward for you and your employer. Let us know and we'll make sure you're on the right route.

What is EPIC / MyIntealth?

Primary-source verification of your qualifications, confirmed directly with the issuing institutions via the MyIntealth portal. It must be underway before MCNZ can process your application — start it early.

How long will I be supervised?

Commonly around 6–12 months on the VOC4 / "equivalent" route, and often up to around 18 months on the VOC3 "as satisfactory as" assessment route. Supervision is about support and safety as you settle into the NZ system, not a mark against you.

How long does the whole thing take?

Vocational applications are commonly assessed within around 20 working days once complete, though timeframes vary — and EPIC, references and the COPS take time to assemble, so begin three to six months before your intended start date.

Can Ethicare manage this with my employer?

Yes — that's the core of what we do for doctors. We secure the role, coordinate the position-and-supervisor approval with your employer, and keep EPIC, references and documents moving in parallel. The registration decision always rests with the Council.

HOW ETHICARE WILL SUPPORT YOU

You don't have to navigate this alone

If you choose to partner with Ethicare, we'll support you from first enquiry through securing your GP role, registration and relocation to your first day at work — with a single point of contact, honest guidance, and help at every stage. We support and guide you through the process; the registration decision always rests with the Medical Council of New Zealand.

READY TO BEGIN?

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